School of Social Work
COLLEGE OF EDUCATION + HUMAN DEVELOPMENT
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Global Social Justice

Applying Amartya Sen's Concepts to Social Work Education

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Social Justice

Core Value in Social Work

Social justice is one of the foundational values and principles of social work.

National Association of Social Workers Code of Ethics: Value of Social Justice

"Social workers' social change efforts are focused primarily on issues of poverty, unemployment, discrimination, and other forms of social injustice" (NASW, 2013).

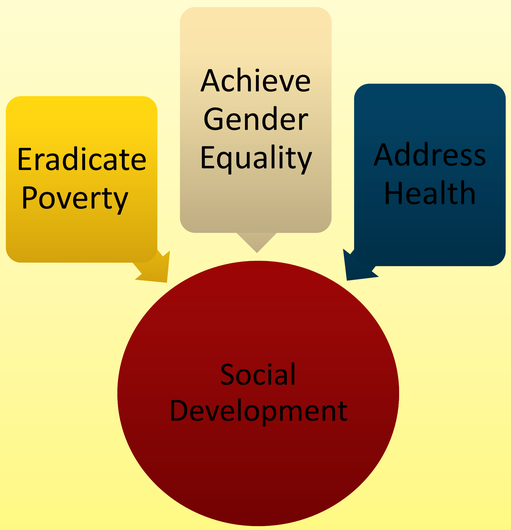
The International Federation of Social Workers (IFSW)

States in their code that the federation strives for social justice, human rights and social development (IRSW, 2011).

However, inequalities worldwide evoke the need to reexamine how the social work profession and education frame key issues such as poverty, inequality and social justice (Gutierrez, et al., 2011).

Global Context, Global Inequality

International Social Work



Amaryta Sen's Concepts

Economist

The work of economist Amartya Sen (1970; 1973; 1999; 2009) who won the **1998 Nobel Memorial Prize in Economic Sciences** for his contributions to:

- welfare economics and
- social choice theory

Sen has extended the notion of justice beyond equal access to resources, such as housing and employment, and conceptualized **social justice as the ability to fully participate in society, including political participation**, and he does so with a global perspective.

Capabilities Approach: Importance of Freedom

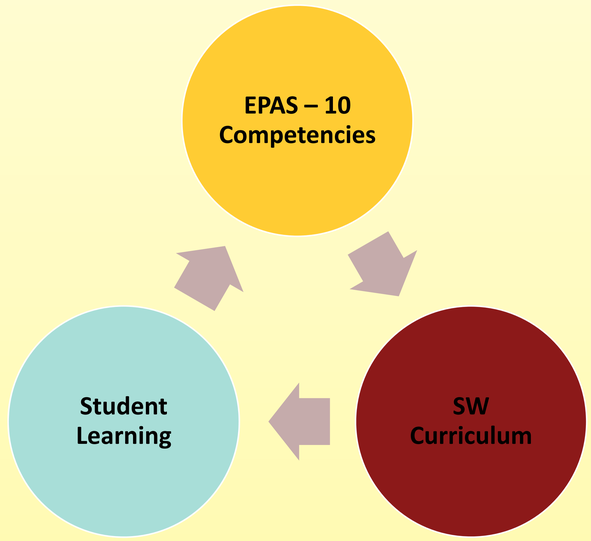
Substantive Freedom	• Being able to avoid hunger and illiteracy, enjoying democratic rights and freedom of speech
Instrumental Freedom	• Having economic and educational opportunities, social protections and safety nets

Sen (1999) defines capability as the freedom and availability of choices to choose different combinations of functionings.

Functionings here can range from **basic needs such as having enough food, good health, and proper shelter, to higher needs such as having self-respect, social and political participation.**

Sen associates the level of capability with the degree of freedom an individual possesses.

Social Work Educational Policy & Accreditation Standards (EPAS)



EPAS 2.1.5 – Advance human rights and social and economic justice

Each person, regardless of position in society, has basic human rights, such as freedom, safety, privacy, an adequate standard of living, health care, and education**. Social workers recognize the global interconnections of oppression and are knowledgeable about theories of justice and strategies to promote human and civil rights**. Social work incorporates social justice practices in organizations, institutions, and society to ensure that these basic human rights are distributed equitably and without prejudice.

Social workers: Practice Behaviors

•Gain a full comprehension about disparities and their development, contribute to knowledge about institutional barriers to equality and apply concentration-appropriate strategies to advance social and economic justice.

Capabilities Approach in Social Work

Ecological Model & Capabilities Approach

The conception of capabilities as a factor that is influenced by social opportunities and other instrumental factors also fits well with the Bronfenbrenner's (1994) ecological system theory.

Limited Application in Social Work Literature

Few authors in the social work literature incorporated and applied Sen's work and ideas to issues central to social work (Banerjee, 2007; Johnson & Sherradan, 2007; Pyles, 2008) despite the fact that these ideas are becoming more central to international social development.

Direct Application to Key Areas of Social Work Education



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